

1 Getting Familiar

back in. Apple acquired NeXTStep and the combined effort was a revamping of the Mac OS X. The development of OS X (pronounced as OS ten and not OS Ex) began in May 1998. The operating system was finally released to the public in March 2001. The OS was a considerable improvement over previous versions and had a slicker interface.

OS X consists of two parts

1. Darwin
2. Aqua

Darwin is the core of the system and is based on BSD (Berkeley Software Distribution). Theoretically, the Unix core makes the operating system a whole lot more stable. However, earlier versions of OS X were noted for the unreliability due to bugs in the kernel.

Aqua is the GUI developed for the operating system. It is based on the theme of water and hence the name. Known for its droplet like buttons with extensive usage of transparency and reflection effects, Aqua was a considerable improvement in the Mac's GUI.

A server version also exists for the OS X. It's very similar to OS X, but has several inbuilt networking tools.

Let's look at the different transitions the OS X went through. The different versions of Mac OS x are as follows:

Cheetah (10.0)

Cheetah, the first version of Mac OS X, was a radical change from the previous versions. It came with a lot of innovative features and a new interface but suffered from several drawbacks. In fact, severe criticism of Mac OS X 10.0 resulted in Apple offering a free upgrade to 10.1 to users.

Cheetah introduced many characteristic features of OS X including the Dock, AppleScript and the Aqua interface. It had native PDF support and was shipped with an email client and address book.

Cheetah came under fire for its sluggish interface. Aqua looked a lot better than previous interfaces, but had slow user interface response speed. The operating system also lacked several features like DVD playback and CD burning, both of which were available in previous versions.

Puma (10.1)

Mac OS X was made the default operating system in Macs after the release of Puma. Puma was better received than Cheetah, but it still lacked features. It introduced image capture to access images from scanners and cameras, the